

8 English Lines That Engineers Use in a Site Safety Briefing

Eight lines for the three minutes before work starts, each with the reason it works and the weaker version it replaces. Listen, then say each one out loud.

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

One thing is different today.

/wʌn θɪŋ ɪz 'dɪfrənt tə'deɪ/

MARKING THE PART THAT IS NEW

INSTEAD OF Right — permits, exclusions, lifts, access, welfare.

Why it works. People stop hearing a briefing they know. Say what is different first. That is when they start listening again.

One thing is different today. The crane is lifting over the west gate from nine.

Isa lang ang naiba ngayon.

2/8

This next part is for the three of you on the east face.

/ðɪs nekst pɑ:t ɪz fɔː ðə θriː ɒv juː ɒn ði iːst feɪs/

NAMING EXACTLY WHO MUST LISTEN

INSTEAD OF Right, everyone, listen up.

Why it works. Everyone means nobody. Each person waits for somebody else to listen. Name the number and the place. Each one checks if it is them.

This next part is for the three of you on the east face. Everybody else can carry on getting ready.

Para sa inyong tatlo sa east face ang susunod na bahagi.

3/8

Nobody goes past the tape until I say so.

/'nəʊbədi ɡəʊz pɑːst ðə teɪp ʌn'tɪl aɪ seɪ səʊ/

GIVING ONE INSTRUCTION WITH NO SECOND READING

INSTEAD OF Try to stay out of that area if you can.

Why it works. Try and if you can sound polite. They also sound optional. One action, one person deciding, nothing to guess.

Nobody goes past the tape until I say so. Not for two minutes, not for anything.

Walang lalampas sa tape hangga't hindi ko sinasabi.

4/8

Tell me what you are going to do first.

/tɛl mi: wɒt ju: ɑ: 'gəʊɪŋ tu: du: fɜ:st/

GETTING ONE PERSON TO SAY IT BACK OUT LOUD

INSTEAD OF Any questions? No? Good.

Why it works. Out here silence can mean yes. It can also mean the wind took it. One person saying it back tells you which. It shows the others that speaking up is allowed.

Tell me what you are going to do first, and I will listen.

Sabihin ninyo sa akin kung ano ang unang gagawin ninyo.

5/8

Musa, before they move off, what have I missed?

/'mu:sə brɪ'fɔ: ðeɪ mu:v ɒf wɒt hæv aɪ mɪst/

ASKING ONE SENIOR PERSON BY NAME, NOT THE CROWD

INSTEAD OF Anything I have missed? Anyone?

Why it works. You cannot ask a crowd. You can ask one person. What have I missed expects an answer. Silence becomes the harder choice.

Musa, before they move off, what have I missed?

Musa, bago sila umalis, ano po ang nakalimutan ko?

6/8

If it does not look right, stop the job and come and find me.

/ɪf ɪt dʌz nɒt lʊk raɪt stɒp ðə dʒɒb ænd kʌm ænd faɪnd mi:/

GIVING PERMISSION TO STOP WORK

INSTEAD OF Just be careful out there today.

Why it works. Be careful gives nobody a thing to do. This gives one action and one person to find. Said out loud, it still works at half past ten.

If it does not look right, stop the job and come and find me. Nobody gets in trouble for that.

Kung mukhang mali, itigil ang trabaho at puntahan ninyo ako.

7/8

I am stopping this until we have checked it.

/aɪ æm 'stɒpɪŋ ðɪs ʌn'tɪl wiː hæv tʃɛkt ɪt/

STOPPING WORK WITHOUT ASKING PERMISSION

INSTEAD OF Do you think we should maybe stop?

Why it works. A question hands the decision back up. A sentence does not. I would rather be wrong lets you both step back.

I am stopping this until we have checked it. I would rather be wrong.

Ihihinto ko po ito hangga't hindi natin nasusuri.

8/8

When you reach the gate, that is when you stop and look up.

/wɛn ju: ri:tʃ ðə geɪt ðæt ɪz wɛn ju: stɒp ænd lʊk ʌp/

TYING AN INSTRUCTION TO THE PLACE IT IS NEEDED

INSTEAD OF Remember to look up for the crane today.

Why it works. Remember today is too big to act on. Nobody holds an instruction for forty minutes. Give it a place they walk past. The place does the remembering.

When you reach the gate, that is when you stop and look up. Not before, and not once you are through.

Pagdating ninyo sa gate, doon kayo huminto at tumingala.

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Mark · Name · Instruct · Check

Four steps, and those four are the briefing. The other four are not. One ties the instruction to a place they will walk past. One asks the foreman, by name, what you missed. One hands the crew the stop. The last one is not part of a briefing at all. It is what you say to somebody senior when the job has to end now.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. The briefing has been word for word the same for six days. Today the crane is lifting over the west gate.

One thing is different today.

People stop hearing a briefing they know. Say what is different first. That is when they start listening again.

2. Twelve people are in front of you and only four of them need what you are about to say.

This next part is for the three of you on the east face.

Everyone means nobody. Each person waits for somebody else to listen. Name the number and the place. Each one checks if it is them.

3. A zone has just been taped off and one man has already stepped over towards it.

Nobody goes past the tape until I say so.

Try and if you can sound polite. They also sound optional. One action, one person deciding, nothing to guess.

4. You have finished. You need to know whether the new subcontractor followed any of it.

Tell me what you are going to do first.

Out here silence can mean yes. It can also mean the wind took it. One person saying it back tells you which. It shows the others that speaking up is allowed.

5. You rushed the last minute of it and you know it. The foreman is standing at your shoulder and the crew is about to move off.

Musa, before they move off, what have I missed?

You cannot ask a crowd. You can ask one person. What have I missed expects an answer. Silence becomes the harder choice.

6. You are sending a crew up scaffold that nobody has looked at since yesterday afternoon.

If it does not look right, stop the job and come and find me.

Be careful gives nobody a thing to do. This gives one action and one person to find. Said out loud, it still works at half past ten.

7. The lift is about to start and the ground under one outrigger has moved. The foreman has twenty years on you.

I am stopping this until we have checked it.

A question hands the decision back up. A sentence does not. I would rather be wrong lets you both step back.

8. The crane is over the west gate from nine. They will reach that gate forty minutes after you stop speaking.

When you reach the gate, that is when you stop and look up.

Remember today is too big to act on. Nobody holds an instruction for forty minutes. Give it a place they walk past. The place does the remembering.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day Day 3

Three days ago you learned the four steps: mark, name, instruct, check. New situation. You are briefing two men who have worked this site far longer than you have. Which of the four steps do people drop first when they feel junior, and which sentence would you make sure you still said?

7/day

Day 7

One week in. This is the one people get wrong. You are the one being briefed, not the one briefing, and it is coming at you far too fast. Two lines from this lesson work from the other side. Can you remember which, and how you would say them without sounding as if you are pulling rank?

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